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User privacy app Cloaked adds AI-powered caller screening

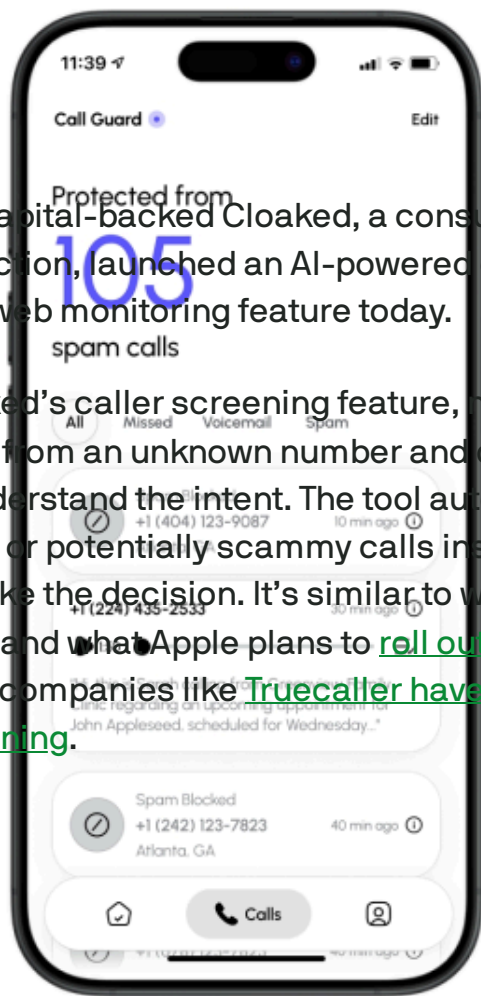


IMAGE CREDITS: CLOAKED

Lux Capital-backed Cloaked, a consumer app for user identity protection, launched an AI-powered caller screening and dark web monitoring feature today.

Cloaked's caller screening feature, named Call Guard, takes a call from an unknown number and converses with the caller to understand the intent. The tool automatically filters out spam or potentially scammy calls instead of relying on users to make the decision. It's similar to what [Google launched for Pixel](#), and what Apple plans to [roll out for iOS 26 users](#). Third-party companies like [Truecaller](#) have also used AI for call screening.

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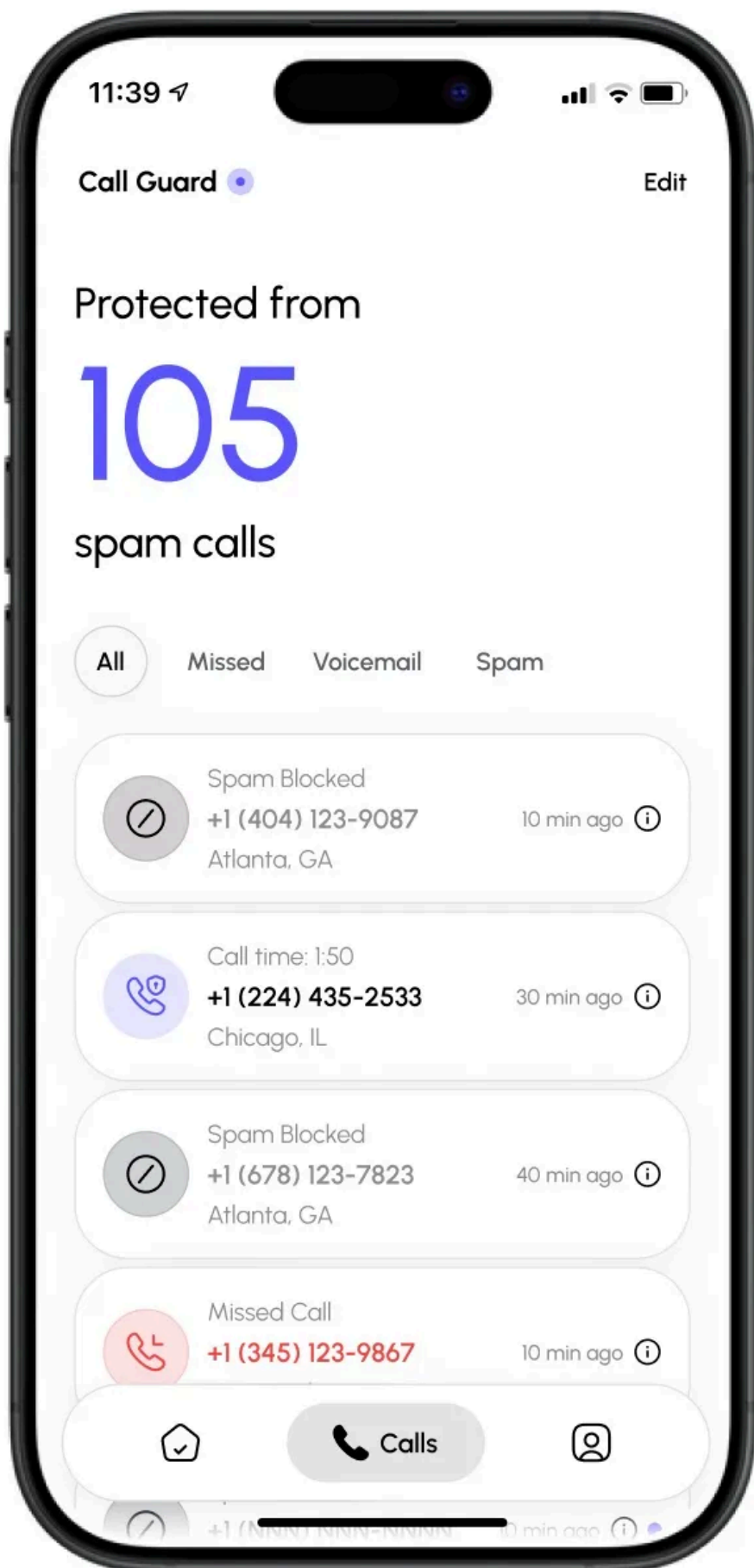


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Users can still see the full transcript of the call in real time in case they want to take over the call. Cloaked had already

worked on developing the phone infrastructure for its identity product that lets users create new phone numbers to mask their real numbers. The startup is taking advantage of that tech, along with call forwarding, to protect users from scams.

“We are trying to understand the intent of the caller using AI rather than just asking the name of the caller and why they are calling. From the data that users have shared with us, a large amount of spam calls and Medicare calls, and then there are political calls. We have also observed that users are now receiving calls from bad AI agents, and we are training our AI agent to tackle that,” [Cloaked](#) CEO Arjun Bhatnagar said.

Bhatnagar acknowledged that Apple and Google’s features are based on a similar premise. He said people sign up to try out these features, but retention numbers are low because of a lack of personalization, and that’s why startups like Cloaked can come in.

While handling inbound calls is the first step for Cloaked, the company wants to enable an outbound call facility that deploys AI-bots to hold the line while on a customer support call or booking appointments. Cloaked is also working on an eSIM product.

Additionally, the startup is releasing a dark web monitor for personal data. The company observes different sources such as data brokers, breach sites, compromised websites, dark web forums, Discord, and Telegram for leaked user data. The tool searches for names, addresses, Social Security numbers, emails, family members, passports, and driver licenses.



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It shows users an alert when it finds such leaked data. The company also bifurcates these leaks into active/recent events and historical events, helping users take action for their data.

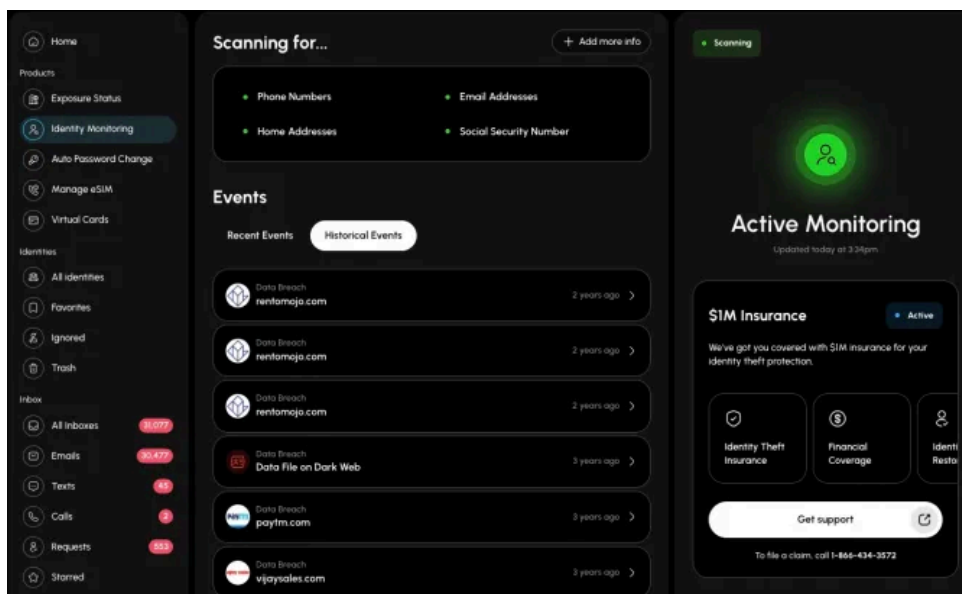


IMAGE CREDITS: CLOAKED

The company also has a data deletion program, through which users can request sites and data brokers to delete data. Cloaked sends programmatic and legal requests to these sites. The startup said it has helped users get rid of more than 170 million records across the web.

Cloaked said that it has added more than 100,000 paying customers since the beginning of the year and is seeing strong month-over-month growth.

Until 2023, the startup [had raised \\$29 million in funding](#). Bhatnagar said that the company has gotten an additional \$11 million in funding from a mix of existing and new investors, but it is not defining the round or disclosing the new investors as it plans to close a formal round by the end of this year.

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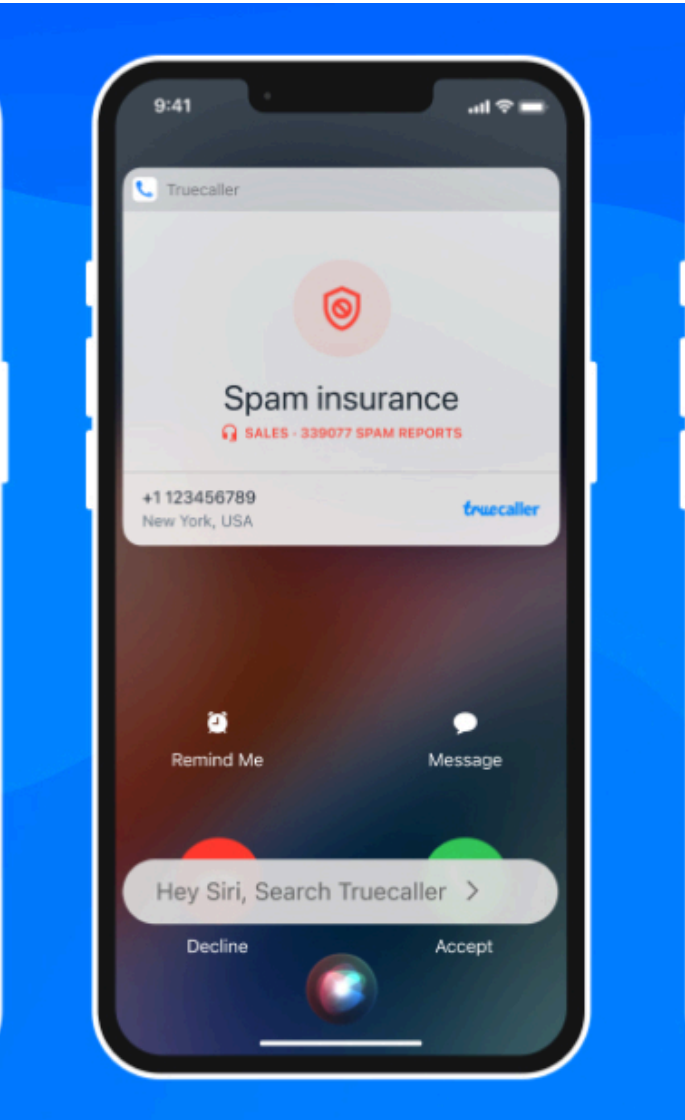


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Truecaller brings live caller ID to iPhone... but with a catch

Jagmeet Singh — 3:30 AM PDT · April 12, 2023

[Truecaller](#) has been a known name in the app market globally — thanks to its eponymous caller-identification service. Its active user base these days numbers 338 million, but it could be bigger: A lack of a caller ID feature on iOS has arguably held back its growth among iPhone users. Now, in an effort to expand its reach, the Stockholm-based company is introducing an update that will finally provide live caller ID support on iOS, available to people using its paid tiers.

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The new feature comes as Truecaller continues to see a lot of growth, but also some knocks in its strongest markets. The app has been one of the more popular ones among mobile users in markets like India where [spammers target the masses](#). Yet the company has faced criticism over how it collects data for its caller ID service.

Last year, an investigation by Indian magazine The Caravan [claimed](#) that Truecaller was “comprised of details which have been collected without consent.” However, the company [denied the allegations](#) and asserted that the investigation was flawed and based on inaccurate information.

The new caller ID feature will be offered only to users who are on the app’s premium tiers (priced at a range of tiers ranging from \$0.99 per month per individual, through to \$4.99/month when a user’s carrier is not supported and \$9.99/month for family plans, with discounts on annual subscriptions).

And it won’t be just like it is on Android: Unlike the seamless experience available on that platform — users see a caller ID instantly when they receive an incoming call — the iPhone experience will involve a step that requires interacting with Siri.

Nakul Kabra, product director for iOS at Truecaller, told TechCrunch that the app has had a limited experience on the iPhone due to how Apple works with third-party caller ID apps.

The current framework for identifying calls in Truecaller is limited to a finite set of numbers stored in directories in Apple’s CallKit framework, chosen by Truecaller’s spam algorithm. That means that other numbers not stored locally require manual search, he said.

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To use the new feature, Truecaller subscribers on an iPhone running on iOS 16 or above will be able to access live caller ID support by saying, “Hey Siri, Search Truecaller.” This will allow Siri to capture the number appearing on the screen, search for it on the app, then show the result to the user.

The feature leverages Apple’s Siri Shortcuts and App Intents to offer the anticipated live caller ID experience.

That means users will need first to enable the Search Truecaller shortcut on their iPhone by tapping the *Add to Siri* option in the Premium tab. The first time the shortcut runs, the user will be prompted to allow Truecaller to search from the screenshots the shortcut captures.

“We have been tinkering around with App Intents for the last few months since iOS 16 was publicly launched... Previous iterations didn’t have the right experience to be used in the context of a live call. One of the more recent iterations is what has evolved into this feature,” Kabra said.

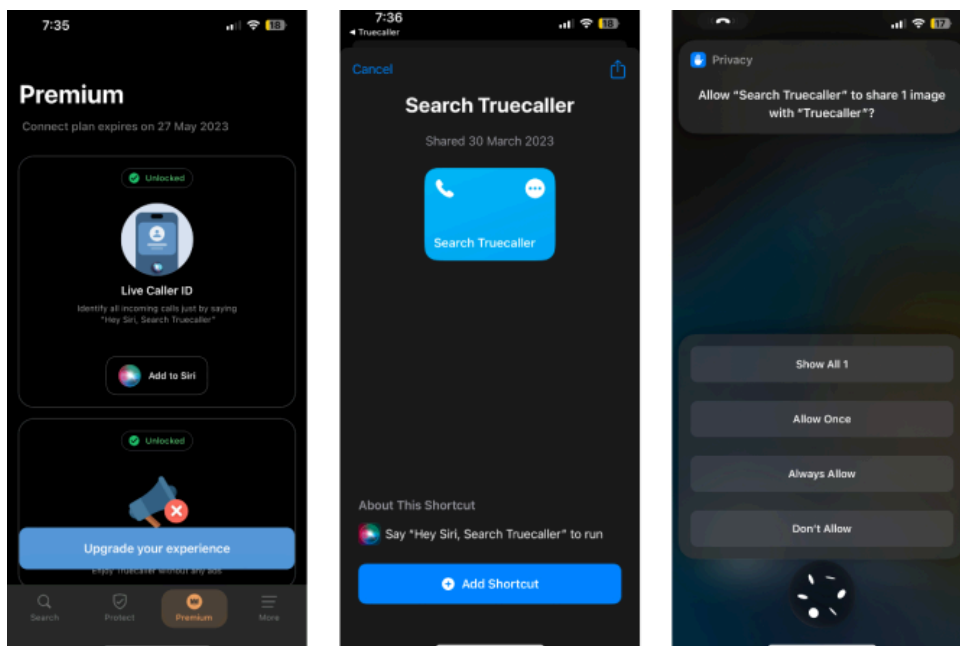


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Users with more recent iPhones, including the iPhone 14 Pro and iPhone 14 Pro Max, will have the option to access the feature without having to call out the Siri phrase and instead will be able to tap the back of their handset. For this, they need to enable the Search Truecaller shortcut from the [Back Tap](#) gesture settings.

With this update, Truecaller has also doubled its CallKit directory size and improved its spam detection algorithm to ensure that spam, scam, and fraud calls are recognized more accurately.

“This improved directory makes sure that most top spam and verified business calls can be identified right away even without needing to ask Siri. However, given the limitations of the platform, we cannot identify all calls using the traditional call directories mechanism. This is where the new Live Caller ID comes in and makes sure that you can identify every single call,” Kabra said.

The company also says premium users’ spam lists will receive daily updates. Meanwhile, free users only have the option to update the list manually.

Truecaller additionally introduced a commenting feature for iPhone users that lets them read user feedback coming on spam calls and even contribute with their own comments. This feature was previously available on Android.

SMS filtering on iOS is also being improved with the ability to categorize incoming text messages into Finance, Orders, Reminders, Coupons, Offers and Junk categories. This categorization is currently live in India, South Africa and Nigeria and will soon be rolled out to other markets.

The new set of features on Truecaller for iPhone comes months after the iOS app received a [revamped experience](#) in August last year. Since then, the company said its daily users on the iPhone had grown more than 80%. The company declined to provide details on how many users it has on iOS in total.

“Live Caller ID on iPhone is the one major aspect that has eluded our iPhone app, and we are excited to finally introduce it with the help of Siri,” said Alan Mamedi, co-founder and CEO at Truecaller, in a prepared statement.

Topics: [Apps](#) [iOS](#) [iPhone](#) [Truecaller](#)

the first major release from the Swedish company after the co-founders Alan Mamedi and Nami Zarringhalam [stepped down from the day-to-day operations](#) in November 2024.

Today, Truecaller has more than 2.6 million paying subscribers, of which only around 750,000 of them are on iOS. However, 40% of Truecaller's Premium revenue is from iOS subscriptions. The company also gets a 5x conversation rate to its premium tier on iOS compared to Android as well as 80% higher revenue from an iPhone subscriber.

Considering the importance of the iPhone to Truecaller's bottom line, the company continues to develop its iOS app.

In 2022, Truecaller [relaunched](#) the iOS app to focus on better spam detection, thanks to Apple allowing the app to store a larger set of numbers locally.

"It did improve the overall call identification. But that wasn't enough because in countries like India, there is a huge calling activity, and not all this would be available in the offline database," Truecaller product director Nakul Kabra told TechCrunch in an interview.

India presents other challenges for the company as well, including the arrival of a service, [Calling Name Presentation](#) ([commonly called CNAP](#)), designed to curb spam. The service, currently being rolled out by local telcos, could eventually emerge as a competitor to Truecaller.

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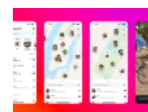
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Truecaller also updated its iOS app in 2023 with a live caller ID experience, but that involved a step requiring [interaction](#) with Siri and also wasn't real time.

Until iOS 18's release, Truecaller had to rely on a locally saved dictionary of limited phone numbers on iOS.

To enable the new feature, Truecaller built a new server architecture and created a separate, encrypted database for iOS, alongside its existing larger database for Android users. Apple's phone app makes encrypted requests to this database and gets encrypted responses that are only decrypted on the client (iPhone) to show the caller ID in real time. This process is called "homomorphic encryption," as the computations use encrypted data instead of decrypting them first, while decryption happens on the client to display caller information if it matches with the data stored on the server.

Kabra told TechCrunch that Truecaller had built a way to sync two databases to keep the data synced between them.

"At the moment, there might be a bit of a delay because these requests get queued up, and the encryption that we do is very time-consuming — and very expensive. ... But it should not be more than a few hours," he said.

TechCrunch tested live caller ID under Truecaller's beta program last week and noticed that the feature does provide caller information in real time in most cases, though it sometimes misses.

Truecaller's premium tier on iOS starts at \$9.99 a month, per individual, or \$74.99/year. The company also offers its family plan on iOS starting at \$14.99/month or \$99.99/year and the top-end Gold subscription at \$249 a year.

Users can enable the Live Caller ID Lookup feature through iPhone Settings > Apps > Phone > Call Blocking & Identification.

On iOS 18, Truecaller also updated its interface with the caller's name appearing in bold over their number. Now Truecaller is working on support for images to show up in the caller ID for its iOS users.





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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

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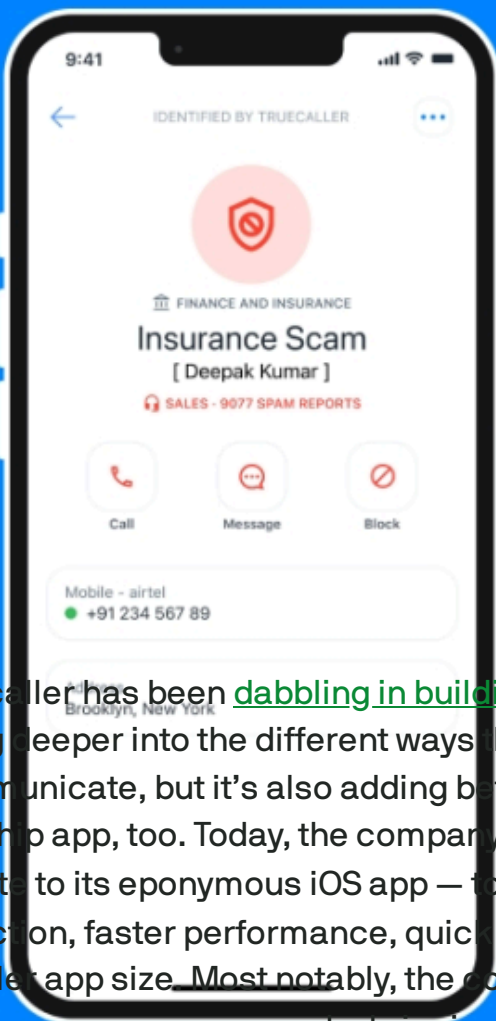
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Truecaller's iOS update aims to improve call and spam detection

Ivan Mehta, Jagmeet Singh

3:41 AM PDT · August 30, 2022



Truecaller has been [dabbling in building out a family of apps](#) to dig deeper into the different ways that people now communicate, but it's also adding better performance to its flagship app, too. Today, the company released a major update to its eponymous iOS app — touting better spam detection, faster performance, quick onboarding and a smaller app size. Most notably, the company says the update addresses user concerns by bringing the iPhone app on par with its Android counterpart for call detection.

IMAGE CREDITS: TRUECALLER

The update comes on the heels of some welcome news for the app from the country's Supreme Court regarding its handling of user data and privacy. Back in March, an investigation [alleged](#) that the platform's datasets were “comprised of details which have been collected without consent.” Just yesterday, however, the Court announced that it would [decline to hear the case](#), effectively closing the door on the matter (for now, at least).

The app update doesn't address any of the issues that were raised in that March investigation: its aim is to improve speed. To improve its call and spam detection, the firm said it rebuilt the iOS app's code base to take better advantage of Apple's CallKit API. In the legacy version, the app could store only a limited list of spam numbers and caller IDs locally. Truecaller claims that the new version can store a 10-times bigger list on the phone to quickly detect callers.

Truecaller also said that the local caller ID list will grow as more people use the newer version. The list gets updated



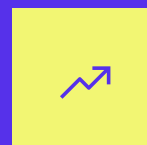
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every three days for free users and every day for premium users for faster caller identification.

The caveat is that to enable features including identifying verified business calls, spam calls, previously searched numbers and calls from other Truecaller users, you need to go to *Settings > Phone > Call Blocking & Identification* and turn on all toggles. This only applies to the iPhone as users on Android are not required to go through the same settings.

Unfortunately, Truecaller doesn't specify any toggle-feature mapping, so you'll have to either enable all of them or adopt a trial and error method for turning on exact features.

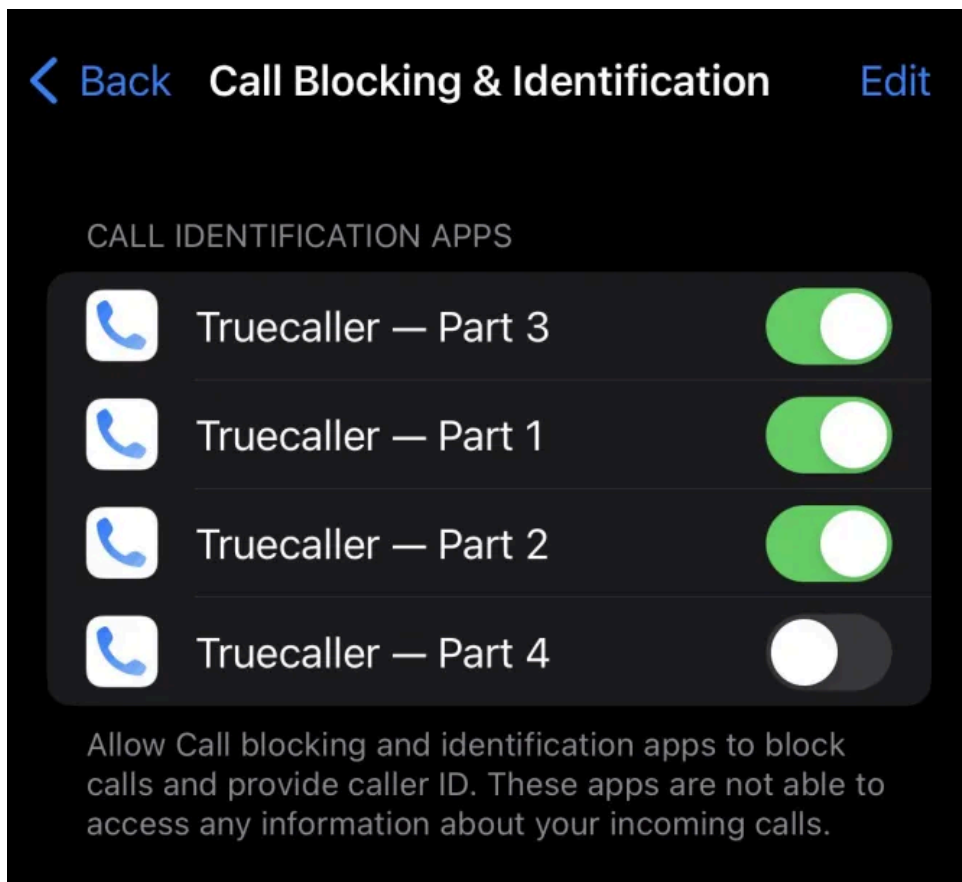
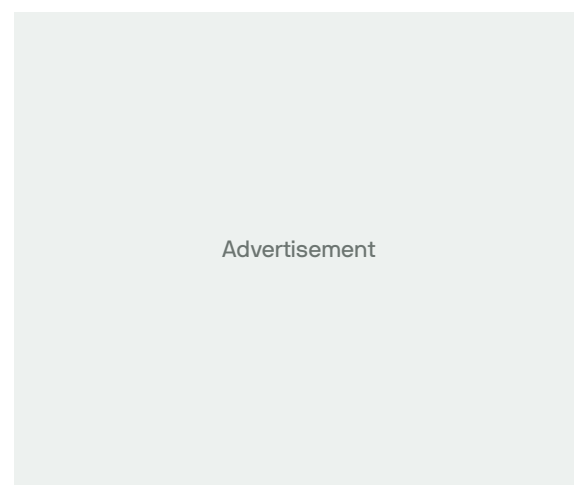


IMAGE CREDITS: TRUECALLER

By rewriting the code, Truecaller claims it delivers a faster experience even on older iPhone models — as far back as the iPhone 6s. The company touts that it has provided a 30% smaller app size overall and 50% speed improvements on most iPhone models. The updated app (version 12.0) also requires your iPhone model to run iOS 14 or later — unlike the earlier version which had iOS 13.0 as the minimum requirement.

The underlying changes also improve the Premium purchase flow to let users easily pick the paid option over the free one — to get an ad-free experience and features such as the ability to see who viewed your profile on the app and unlock “advanced” spam blocking. Moreover, users will start seeing

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a search icon next to the phone numbers they've already searched on the app.



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Because Truecaller's spam detection relies on user reports to a large extent, the performance of features including live identification of pesky spam and scam calls on the iPhone will take some time to bring any noticeable improvements.

"This update has been a long time coming for many iPhone users, and now we can offer them the best performing identifier of spam and scam to help them separate the noise from the communication they want to respond to," said Alan Mamedi, co-founder and CEO of Truecaller, in a prepared statement.

Truecaller also plans to align the experience with the release of iOS 16 in the coming months by bringing features [including advanced SMS filtering](#). Furthermore, it is working on introducing an ability to automatically block top spammers and let iPhone users view detailed statistics on spam-marked numbers as well as view and contribute comments on its spam-marked numbers for additional context. Though, exact details on when these updates will be available are yet to be announced.

Currently, iPhone users account for 5% of Truecaller's total base of 320 million monthly active users. The company, though, seems to be working on expanding its presence among Apple consumers by introducing new updates.

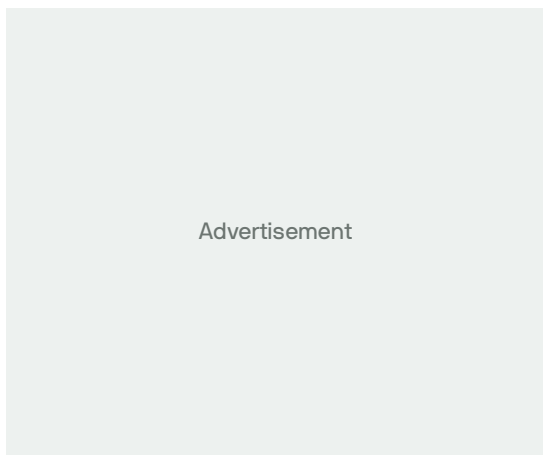
Truecaller works by asking users to give access to their phonebooks for caller ID and collecting reports about spam numbers from its community. Because of this model, the company has data of people who might not have given consent for their number to be shared. To mitigate that, the firm offers [unlisting services](#) for users who don't want their ID to be on service.

The way that Truecaller detects and handles its caller ID service has raised privacy concerns in the recent past. The investigation carried by Rest of World and Caravan India earlier this year alleged serious issues related to that. However, the company [refuted the allegations](#) in a blog post and said that the investigation was based on inaccuracies.

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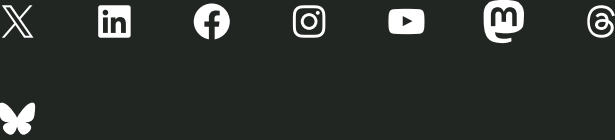
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